THE VIRAL STARS



GAJRAJ RAO
Before *Badhaai Ho*, Rao had already made an impression as the eponymous Dad in its most-watched sketch *Truth or Dare with Dad* and *Tech Conversations with Dad*

AHSAAS CHANNA
With TVF shows like *Girls Hostel*, *Kota Factory*, *Hostel Daze* and *The Interns* under her kitty, Channa, at 22, is one of TVF's bright stars

NAVEEN KASTURIA
An erstwhile assistant director, widely viewed shows like *Pitchers* and *Aspirants* have ensured that Kasturia remains in front of the camera

JITENDRA KUMAR
Kumar's stint on *Pitchers*, *Bachelors*, *F.A.T.H.E.R.S* and *Kota Factory* has meant that he is now referred to as the character "Jeetu Bhaiya" among his legion of young fans

MAANVI GAGROO
Gagroo's first noteworthy gig was as Chanchal Sharma, the sister who embarks on a road trip with her brothers, in TVF's *Tripling*

a service-oriented one. "We are in the business of making platform-agnostic content," says Pandey. "If we just take briefs from platforms and make shows, then it is a very murky space." On most occasions, TVF pitches the show to an OTT service after it is wrapped.

With great success comes the need to deliver the goods quickly. The challenge for Pandey has been to meet expectations and maintain quality. "Around 2018-19, I noticed that people praise our shows but at the same time tease that '*slow kaam karte ho*' (you guys work at a slow pace)," says Pandey. In the past year or so, TVF has scaled up its operations to try and ensure that a subsequent season is produced within a year. This means its executive creative directors like Palash Vaswani, Deepak Kumar Mishra, Raghav Subbu and creative directors like Anant Singh, Shreyasi Sharma and Vaibhav Bundhoo have their hands full.

BREAKING THE MOULD

Every company, as it grows in stature, finds itself stuck with a genre. Humour is seen as TVF's forte given that its journey started with spoofs and sketches, which it continues to make on its four YouTube channels. The short form content is the foundation for most TVF filmmakers. "They gave us a sense of storytelling," says Mishra. "Our sketches are hit not just because they are funny but also because there's a story, a structure." What they also do is give creators "instant feedback". "You know exactly which joke is landing and whatever is working or not," adds Vaswani.

TVF, though, has gradually begun to challenge the notion of being a laugh factory as the latest seasons of *Panchayat* and *Gullak* demonstrate. "Our creative upbringing tells us that good drama has to be backed by great jokes," says Dwivedi, as he singled out his favourite shows *The Wire*, *Breaking Bad* and *The Sopranos*. Team TVF subscribes to *Fleabag* creator Phoebe Waller Bridge's diktat: Disarm the audience with comedy, then punch them in the gut with drama.

TVF is also fighting another common perception that its shows are made on modest budgets. "Authentic *rehna* has become our curse," says Kumar, who has dealt with criticism of the shows lacking "production value". "They say we are not doing escapist, larger-than-life cinema." Pandey explains how telling a real and relatable story also comes at a price. "At times, I feel recreating the real is more difficult and time-consuming," he adds. For *Panchayat*, the makers dug up a pond and brought tankers to fill water and built a road so that a vanity van could reach Mahodia, a village near Bhopal, where the show is shot.

Even as it succeeds in doing what it knows best, TVF in the coming years is keen to push the envelope. In the pipeline is a sci-fi show that Kumar has developed. Another one in the works is against the backdrop of cricket. Its first feature may not be a Hindi film. Mishra mentions the possibility of making shows "where there are no jokes". Regardless of it, OTT platforms will be keen to collaborate with it. For Kumar, the winning formula is TVF's democratic set-up. "We call each other's bluff," he says. "I make sure nobody sits on a pedestal." ■